

English Grammar and Usage for the CRT

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What UPSC asks on this

1. **Spot the error:** a sentence split into three parts plus "No error". The fault is almost always agreement, tense, preposition, article or pronoun.
2. **Fill in the blank:** the right preposition, article, verb form or paired conjunction.
3. **Transformation:** active to passive, direct to indirect speech, sometimes degree of comparison.
4. **Vocabulary:** synonym, antonym, idiom or phrase, one-word substitution, confused word pair.
5. **Sentence improvement** and **sentence or paragraph rearrangement**.
6. **Short reading comprehension** passage with a few questions on facts, inference and tone.

How the English section behaves

Summary: the marks come from a small set of rules applied to ordinary sentences, so learn the rules, not the sentences.

The syllabus line is "Hindi and English language skills". In UPSC Recruitment Test papers that carry a General Ability Test, the English questions are short, objective and rule-based. They test whether you recognise correct usage, not whether you can name grammatical terms.

Negative marking is one-third of the question's marks. In error spotting, if two parts are definitely correct, choose between the remaining part and "No error". "No error" is sometimes the key, so do not force a correction where nothing is wrong. Use this order of checks:

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`mermaid flowchart TD
  A[Read the whole sentence] --> B[Find subject and verb]
  B --> C[Check number agreement]
  C --> D[Check tense and time words]
  D --> E[Check preposition pairs]
  E --> F[Check article and noun]
  F --> G[Check pronoun and comparison]
  G --> H[All pass means No error]
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Subject-verb agreement

Summary: find the real subject, ignore everything between it and the verb, then match number.

Why the rule exists: English marks number only in the present tense and in *was/were*, so the examiner hides the subject behind a phrase to see whether you can still find it.

- **Words between subject and verb do not count.**
"The Principal, **along with** the teachers, **is** attending." The same holds for *as well as*, *together with*, *with*, *in addition to*, *accompanied by*, *no less than*, *like*, *besides*, *except*.
- **Two subjects joined by "and" take a plural verb**, unless they name one person or one idea. "The Vice Principal and the DDO **are** present" (two people), but "The Vice Principal and DDO **is** present" (one

person holding both charges). "Bread and butter **is** his breakfast."

- **Either...or, neither...nor, or, not only...but also: the verb agrees with the nearer subject.** "Neither the Principal nor the teachers **were** present." "Neither the teachers nor the Principal **was** present."
- **Each, every, everyone, anyone, nobody, either, neither, many a, more than one** take a singular verb. "Each of the students **has** a copy." "Many a teacher **has** asked." "More than one section **was** affected."
- **A number of + plural noun takes a plural verb; the number of takes a singular verb.** "A number of teachers **have** applied." "The number of applicants **is** large."
- **Collective nouns** (*staff, committee, team, class, jury, government*) are singular when the group acts as one: "The committee **has** submitted **its** report." They are plural only when members act separately: "The committee **were** divided in their opinion." A mix such as "The committee **have** submitted **its** report" is wrong.
- **Fractions and quantity words take the number of the noun after "of":** "Half of the work **is** done." "Half of the students **are** present." Same for *most of, some of, all of, a lot of, plenty of, the rest of*.
- **Sums, distances and periods counted as one amount are singular:** "Five thousand rupees **is** the fee." "Three hours **is** enough for the paper."

- **Relative pronouns carry the number of their antecedent:** "She is one of the teachers who **have** been selected" (*who* points to *teachers*). But "She is the **only one** of the teachers who **has** been selected." "It is I who **am** responsible."
- **Here/There + verb: look at the noun after the verb:** "There **are** two vacancies." "Here **is** the file."
- **Plural in form, singular in meaning:** *news, mathematics, physics, economics, politics, measles, the United States*. "Mathematics **is** compulsory." Always plural: *scissors, trousers, spectacles, premises, police, cattle, people, children, alms, thanks, proceeds, belongings*. "The police **have** arrived."

School example: a notice reads "The list of selected candidates are displayed." The subject is *list*, not *candidates*: "The list ... **is** displayed."

Memory aid: "**Along with**" leaves the first subject **alone**. Only "**and**" adds a subject; every other joining phrase is ignored.

Nouns and pronouns

Summary: uncountable nouns have no plural and no "a", and pronoun case depends on the job the pronoun does.

- **Uncountable nouns:** *advice, information, furniture, luggage, baggage, news, scenery, poetry, hair, equipment, stationery, machinery, homework, evidence, progress, knowledge, bread*. Never "an advice", "informations", "furnitures", "equipments".

Count them with a unit: "a piece of advice", "two items of furniture".

- **Foreign plurals** UPSC likes: criterion → **criteria**, phenomenon → **phenomena**, datum → **data**, medium → **media**, curriculum → **curricula**, syllabus → **syllabi/syllabuses**, alumnus → **alumni**, memorandum → **memoranda**, formula → **formulae/formulas**, index → **indices**, basis → **bases**, analysis → **analyses**. "The criteria **are** clear" but "The criterion **is** clear."
- **Number words used as adjectives stay singular**: "a **two-hour** test", "a **five-year** plan", "a **ten-rupee** note", "**two hundred** students". Plural only when used as nouns: "hundreds of students".
- **Possessive**: use 's for living things and for time or distance ("a **week's** leave", "a **day's** work"); use *of* for objects ("the leg **of** the table").
- **Pronoun case**: object case after prepositions and verbs: "between you and **me**", "Let him and **me** go". After *than/as* use the case the full clause needs: "She is taller than **I** (am)"; "He helped me more than (he helped) **her**."
- **Order of persons**: second, third, first in ordinary sentences (**231**: "You, he and I"); first, second, third when admitting a fault (**123**: "I, you and he are to blame").
- **Reflexive verbs** need *oneself*: *avail oneself of*, *absent oneself from*, *enjoy oneself*, *pride oneself on*, *apply oneself to*, *exert oneself*. "He absented

himself from duty." "She availed **herself of** the opportunity."

- **Each other** for two, **one another** for more than two (the exam rule).
- **Who/whom/which/that:** *whom* is the object ("the teacher **whom** we met"); *which* for things; *that* after superlatives and after *all, same, only, any, nothing*: "the best school **that** I know".
- **Antecedent agreement:** "Every student must bring **his or her** identity card." "Each of the girls has **her** own locker." Exam English does not accept *their* for a singular antecedent.

School example: "The staff has submitted **their** reports" is wrong because *staff* is singular here. Write "**its** reports" or recast as "The staff members have submitted their reports."

Tenses and conditionals

Summary: time words decide the tense, and the earlier of two past actions takes the past perfect.

- **Present perfect never sits with a finished-time word.** "I **met** him yesterday" (not *have met*).
Yesterday, last week, in 2019, ago need the simple past. *Just, already, yet, ever, never, so far, since, for* go with the present perfect.
- **Since + point of time; for + length of time.** "She has been working here **since 2018**" or "**for seven years**." With *since* the main verb is in a perfect tense.

- **Past perfect** for the action that happened first: "The bell **had rung** before the students **entered**." With only one past action, use the simple past.
- **Time clauses take the present, not the future:** "When the DEO **comes**, I **will** inform you." Same after *as soon as, till, until, before, after, unless, if*.
- **Conditionals** (never *would* in the if-clause):

Type	If-clause	Main clause
Real (open)	simple present	will + verb
Unreal present	simple past (were)	would + verb
Unreal past	past perfect	would have + V3

"If I **were** the Principal, I **would** change the timetable."

"If he **had studied**, he **would have passed**." Wrong: "If he would have studied."

- **Stative verbs avoid the continuous:** *know, believe, understand, own, belong, want, like, hate, prefer, seem, contain*. "I **know** the answer" (not *am knowing*).
- **Sequence of tenses:** a past main verb pulls the subordinate verb into the past: "He said that he **was** ill." Exception: universal truths and habits stay present: "He said that the earth **revolves** round the sun."
- **Paired conjunctions:** *no sooner ... than; hardly/scarcely ... when; not only ... but also; both ... and; either ... or; neither ... nor; lest ... should; so ... that; such ... that*. "**No sooner** had the bell rung

than the students rushed out." "**Hardly** had I reached **when** it started raining."

- **Unless** already contains *not*: "Unless you work hard, you will fail" (not *unless you do not*).
- **Used to / be used to**: "She **used to teach** Hindi" (past habit) but "She **is used to teaching** Hindi" (accustomed; *-ing* form).

Memory aid: "**Since the point, for the period.**" "**If never takes would.**"

Articles

Summary: a/an go by sound, "the" goes by definiteness, and some nouns take no article at all.

- **a/an by the first sound, not the first letter:** *an hour, an honest man, an heir, an MLA, an FIR, an NGO, an X-ray, an SMC meeting; a university, a European, a one-rupee note, a union, a useful book, a hotel.*
- **"The"** with: superlatives and ordinals (*the best, the first*); unique things (*the sun, the sky*); rivers, seas, mountain ranges, deserts and island groups (*the Yamuna, the Himalayas, the Thar, the Andamans*); plural or descriptive country names (*the Netherlands, the USA, the UAE*); newspapers and holy books (*The Hindu, the Gita*); musical instruments (*play the harmonium*); adjectives used as nouns (*the poor, the blind*); famous buildings and ships (*the Red Fort, the Qutub Minar*); *the same, the only, the whole.*

- **No article** with: languages (*Hindi, English*); meals (*breakfast*); most diseases (*fever, cancer*); uncountable nouns used generally (*information, advice*); subjects (*mathematics*); *school, college, hospital, church, bed, prison, court* used for their purpose ("go to **school**", but "went to **the** school to meet the Principal").
- **A/an in a rate sense**: "twice **a** week", "Rs 500 **a** month".
- **One article for one person, two for two**: "the Principal and Secretary" (one person); "the Principal and the Secretary" (two).

School example: "She is a MLA's daughter" is wrong because MLA begins with the sound /em/: "**an** MLA's daughter".

Prepositions

Summary: most preposition questions test a fixed pair, so learn the pairs as units.

Verbs that take **no preposition** (the trap is to add one): *discuss (about), enter (into) a room, reach (to), resemble (to), order (for), attack (on), accompany (with), answer (to), approach (to), comprise (of), emphasise (on), stress (on), request (for), marry (with), obey (to)*. Some related phrases and noun forms do take one: *enter into* an agreement (a different sense of the verb), *lay emphasis on, a request for*.

Pairs that change meaning:

Pair	Use
agree with / agree to	with a person / to a proposal
differ with / differ from	with a person in opinion / from a thing in nature
angry with / angry at	with a person / at a thing
die of / die from	of a disease / from a wound or cause
compare with / compare to	same kind / unlike things (metaphor)
between / among	two / more than two
by / till	deadline ("by Monday") / continuing ("till Monday")
in time / on time	early enough / exactly punctual
beside / besides	next to / in addition to
at / on / in (time)	clock time / day and date / month, year, season

Other fixed phrases: *senior, junior, superior, inferior, prior, preferable to; prefer tea to coffee; good at; fond of, afraid of, capable of, accused of, charged with; blame for, insist on; depend on; rely on; succeed in; suffer from; consist of, in accordance with; according to; despite (never despite of); in spite of, sympathy for, sympathise with; indifferent to; different from; married to; divided into parts; divided among three people.*

School example: "The DDO insisted on me to sign the register" becomes "insisted on **my signing**" or "insisted **that I sign**".

Adjectives, adverbs and comparison

Summary: compare like with like, use the right degree for the count, and exclude the thing itself with "other".

- **Comparative for two, superlative for three or more:** "Of the two sections, XII-A is the **better**." "Of all the sections, XII-A is the **best**."
- **"Than any other":** "Delhi has more government schools than **any other** city." Without *other*, Delhi is compared with itself.
- **Latin comparatives take "to", not "than":** *senior, junior, superior, inferior, prior* (and the verb *prefer*). "He is senior **to** me."
- **Double comparison is wrong:** "more better", "most tallest".
- **Absolute adjectives have no degree:** *unique, perfect, complete, round, square, dead, universal*. Not "more unique".
- **Elder/eldest** for family members and never with *than*; **older/oldest** everywhere else. "My elder brother is older than I."
- **Fewer** for countable, **less** for uncountable: "fewer students", "less time". **Many/much** split the same way. **Few** = hardly any, **a few** = some, **the few** = all the small number there is; *little, a little, the little* do the same job for uncountables.
- **Adverbs:** *hard* (with effort) vs *hardly* (scarcely); *late* vs *lately* (recently). "He works **hard**" and "He **hardly** works" are opposites. Put *only* next to the word it

limits: "**Only** she attended" vs "She attended **only** the first session."

- **Enough** follows an adjective but precedes a noun: "good **enough**", "**enough** time".
- **Verbs of sense take adjectives**: "The soup tastes **good**", "She looks **happy**".
- **Comparison of equals**: *as ... as*; in the negative *so ... as* is also correct.

Memory aid for the "to" group: **S-J-S-I-P-P** (senior, junior, superior, inferior, prior, prefer) all point **to**.

Active and passive voice

Summary: the object moves to the front, the verb becomes be + past participle in the same tense, and the doer goes after "by".

``mermaid flowchart TD A[Find the object] --> B[Make it the subject] B --> C[Add be in same tense] C --> D[Add past participle V3] D --> E[Add by plus doer] E --> F[Drop obvious doer] ``

Tense	Active	Passive
Present simple	teaches	is/are taught
Present continuous	is teaching	is/are being taught
Present perfect	has taught	has/have been taught
Past simple	taught	was/were taught
Past continuous	was teaching	was/were being taught
Past perfect	had taught	had been taught
Future simple	will teach	will be taught
Modal	can/must teach	can/must be taught

Perfect continuous tenses and the future continuous are not normally put into the passive.

- **Imperatives:** "Shut the door." → "Let the door **be shut**." "Please help the new students." → "You **are requested to** help the new students." "Keep the lab clean." → "The lab **should be kept** clean."
- **Questions:** "Who taught you?" → "**By whom** were you taught?" "Did she submit the report?" → "**Was** the report submitted by her?"
- **Two objects:** "The Principal gave the students prizes." → "The students were given prizes" or "Prizes were given to the students."
- **Prepositional verbs keep the preposition:** "The class laughed at him." → "He was laughed **at** by the class."
- **Drop the agent** when it is obvious or unknown: "Someone has stolen my bag." → "My bag has been stolen."
- **Some passives take a different preposition:** *known to, surprised at, pleased with, interested in, satisfied with*. "Everyone knows him." → "He is known **to** everyone."

Direct and indirect speech

Summary: when the reporting verb is in the past, shift the tense back, change the pronouns, and change words of time and place.

Why the rule exists: the reported words were spoken at an earlier time and place, so every marker of "here and now" must move.

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``mermaid flowchart TD
  A[Is reporting verb past] --> B[Yes: shift tense back]
  A --> C[No: keep tense]
  B --> D[Change pronouns]
  C --> D
  D --> E[Change time and place words]
  E --> F[Statement: add that]
  E --> G[Question: if or wh-word]
  E --> H[Command: to-infinitive]
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- **Tense shift** (past reporting verb): present simple → past simple; present continuous → past continuous; present perfect → past perfect; past simple → past perfect; *will* → *would*; *shall* → *should*; *can* → *could*; *may* → *might*; *must* → *had to*. Past perfect and *would*, *could*, *should*, *might*, *ought to* do not change.
- **No shift** when the reporting verb is present or future ("He says that he **is** busy"), and for universal truths, habits and proverbs ("The teacher said that water **boils** at 100 degrees").
- **Words that change**: now → then; today → that day; tonight → that night; tomorrow → the next day; yesterday → the previous day; ago → before; here → there; this → that; these → those; last week → the previous week; next year → the following year.
- **Statements**: *said to* → *told*; add *that*. "He said to me, 'I am busy.'" → "He **told** me **that** he **was** busy."
- **Questions**: use *asked*; *if/whether* for yes-no questions, the *wh*-word otherwise; no *that*; statement word order; no question mark. "She said to him, 'Where do you live?'" → "She asked him **where he lived**." "He said, 'Are you ready?'" → "He asked **if I was** ready."

- **Commands and requests:** *ordered, requested, advised, urged, forbade* + *to*-infinitive. "The teacher said to the boys, 'Do not run in the corridor.'" → "The teacher **advised** the boys **not to run** in the corridor." *Forbade* already carries *not*: "forbade the boys **to run**".
- **Exclamations:** "He said, 'Alas! I have failed.'" → "He **exclaimed with sorrow that** he had failed."
- **Let us:** "She said, 'Let us start the assembly.'" → "She **suggested** (or **proposed**) **that they should** start the assembly."

School example: Direct: The Principal said, "The result will be declared tomorrow." Indirect: The Principal said that the result **would be declared the next day**.

Vocabulary: idioms, one-word substitutions, confused words

Summary: these are recall questions, so a short list learnt well beats a long list skimmed.

Idioms that recur in UPSC and SSC papers:

- **turn a deaf ear:** ignore deliberately · **leave no stone unturned:** make every effort · **at loggerheads:** in strong disagreement · **take with a pinch of salt:** doubt the truth of · **a red-letter day:** a memorable day · **by leaps and bounds:** very rapidly · **in the long run:** eventually · **a bone of contention:** cause of a quarrel · **beat about the bush:** avoid the main point · **bring to book:** punish · **turn over a new leaf:** change for the better · **hit the nail on the head:** say exactly the right thing · **cut no ice:** have no effect ·

at the eleventh hour: at the last moment · **call a spade a spade:** speak bluntly · **a white elephant:** a costly, useless possession · **burn the midnight oil:** study late at night · **once in a blue moon:** very rarely · **in black and white:** in writing · **a feather in one's cap:** an achievement to be proud of · **through thick and thin:** in good times and bad · **nip in the bud:** stop at an early stage · **get the sack:** be dismissed · **a wild goose chase:** a futile search · **on the cards:** likely to happen.

One-word substitutions with a school or office flavour:

- new to a job: **novice** · does something for pleasure, not money: **amateur** · knows everything: **omniscient** · all-powerful: **omnipotent** · speech without preparation: **extempore** · list of books: **bibliography** · one's own life story: **autobiography** · uses both hands equally well: **ambidextrous** · hates mankind: **misanthrope** · loves mankind: **philanthropist** · speaks many languages: **polyglot** · short witty saying: **epigram** · government by officials: **bureaucracy** · of the same age or time: **contemporary** · cannot be corrected: **incorrigible** · cannot be read: **illegible** · disease spreading widely: **epidemic** · study of teaching methods: **pedagogy** · beautiful handwriting: **calligraphy** · agreed by all: **unanimous** · stays away from school without permission: **truant** · collection of poems: **anthology** · speaks little: **reticent** · believes easily: **credulous** · abstains from alcohol: **teetotaler** · word opposite in meaning: **antonym**.

Confused pairs (one-line contrast):

- **affect** (verb, to influence) / **effect** (noun, result)
- **advice** (noun) / **advise** (verb); **practice** (noun) / **practise** (verb) in British English
- **principal** (head of school; main) / **principle** (rule)
- **stationery** (paper, pens) / **stationary** (not moving)
- **complement** (completes) / **compliment** (praise)
- **personal** (private) / **personnel** (staff)
- **council** (a body) / **counsel** (advice; a lawyer)
- **eminent** (famous) / **imminent** (about to happen)
- **precede** (go before) / **proceed** (go on)
- **access** (entry) / **excess** (too much)
- **its** (possessive) / **it's** (it is); **lose** (verb) / **loose** (not tight)
- **farther** (distance) / **further** (additional)
- **childish** (silly) / **childlike** (innocent); **historic** (important) / **historical** (about history); **economic** (of the economy) / **economical** (thrifty)
- **ensure** (make certain) / **insure** (cover by insurance) / **assure** (tell confidently)
- **continual** (repeated with breaks) / **continuous** (without a break)
- **emigrate** (leave a country) / **immigrate** (enter a country)

Memory aid: the **principal** is your **pal**; a **principle** is a **rule**. Stationery has **e** for **envelope**.

Sentence arrangement and comprehension

Summary: find the opening sentence by what it introduces, then chain the rest by pronouns and linkers.

- The **first** sentence names the topic with a full noun phrase ("A School Development Plan is...") and does not start with *it, this, they, however, therefore, but, also*.
- Chain by reference: a sentence with *this plan, the committee, it* must follow the sentence that introduced that noun.
- Chain by time and logic: *then, after that, finally, as a result, however*.
- Fix the pair you are surest of and eliminate options that break it. Two eliminations usually leave the answer.
- Comprehension: read the questions first, then the passage. Answers to "according to the passage" questions must be stated in the passage, not drawn from outside knowledge. For "title" or "main idea" questions pick the option that covers the whole passage, not one paragraph.

Ten solved error-spotting examples

Summary: apply the checklist in order: subject, tense, preposition, article, pronoun, comparison.

1. "One of the teacher has not submitted the marks."
One of needs a plural noun: "one of the **teachers** has". Shortcut: *one of* + plural noun + singular verb.

2. "The quality of the answer sheets were poor."
Subject is *quality*: "**was** poor". Shortcut: cross out the *of*-phrase, then match.
3. "He has joined the school in 2019." *In 2019* is finished time: "He **joined**". Shortcut: finished-time word → simple past.
4. "The students entered into the hall quietly." *Enter* a place takes no preposition: "**entered** the hall".
Shortcut: *enter into* only for agreements.
5. "The DDO is senior than the Head Clerk." Latin comparative: "senior **to**".
6. "Neither of the two candidates were eligible."
Neither is singular: "**was** eligible".
7. "She is more wiser than her colleague." Double comparative: "**wiser** than".
8. "The Principal asked that why I was late." Reported questions take no *that*: "asked **why** I was late".
9. "If it will rain tomorrow, the sports day will be postponed." No future in the if-clause: "If it **rains** tomorrow".
10. "He gave me an useful information." Two faults: *a useful* (sound /ju:/) and *information* is uncountable: "**a useful piece of information**".

Three transformations:

1. Active: "The committee is reviewing the fee structure." Passive: "The fee structure **is being reviewed** by the committee." (present continuous → is being + V3)

2. Direct: "She said to me, 'Have you finished the audit?'" Indirect: "She **asked me whether I had finished** the audit." (yes-no question → whether; present perfect → past perfect)
3. Direct: "The teacher said, 'Honesty is the best policy.'" Indirect: "The teacher said that honesty **is** the best policy." (universal truth, no shift)

Common traps

- A phrase after *along with*, *as well as*, *together with* that looks like a second subject. Only *and* adds a subject.
- *The number of* (singular) swapped with *a number of* (plural).
- Present perfect with a finished-time word: "has joined in 2019", "have met him yesterday".
- An extra preposition after *discuss*, *enter*, *reach*, *comprise*, *resemble*, *order*, *attack*.
- *Than* after *senior*, *junior*, *superior*, *inferior*, *prior*, *prefer*.
- *a/an* chosen by letter instead of sound: "a hour", "an university", "a MLA".
- Plurals of uncountables: *advices*, *furnitures*, *informations*, *equipments*, *sceneries*.
- *Would* inside an if-clause; *not* after *unless*.
- A reported question with *that* or with question word order: "asked that where was I".
- *Tomorrow*, *yesterday*, *here*, *now* left unchanged in indirect speech.

- *Less* with countables ("less students"); *between* with more than two; *each other* for more than two.
- "Than any city" without *other*; "more unique"; "more better".
- A sentence with no error at all. If every check passes, mark "No error".

Remember for the exam

1. *Along with, as well as, together with, with*: the verb agrees with the first subject.
2. *Either...or, neither...nor*: the verb agrees with the nearer subject.
3. *A number of* → plural verb; *the number of* → singular verb.
4. *Each, every, everyone, nobody, either, neither, many a, more than one* → singular verb.
5. *Furniture, advice, information, news, luggage, scenery, equipment, stationery* are uncountable: no -s, no *a/an*, singular verb.
6. *a/an* by sound: an hour, an MLA, an FIR; a university, a European, a one-rupee note.
7. *Since* + point of time; *for* + period. No present perfect with *yesterday, ago, in 2019*.
8. Past perfect for the earlier of two past actions; present tense in time clauses after *when, until, as soon as*.
9. If + past perfect → *would have* + V3. *Would* never enters the if-clause.
10. No preposition after *discuss, enter (a place), reach, resemble, comprise, order, attack*.

11. *Senior, junior, superior, inferior, prior, prefer* take *to*.
12. "Than any **other** city"; comparative for two, superlative for three or more.
13. Passive = object as subject + *be* in the same tense + V3 + *by* doer.
14. Indirect speech: shift the tense back; *will* → *would*; *tomorrow* → *the next day*, *yesterday* → *the previous day*; *now* → *then*; *here* → *there*.
15. Reporting verb in present or future, or a universal truth: no tense change.

Sources

- Wren & Martin, *High School English Grammar and Composition*, S. Chand (revised edition; chapters on agreement, tenses, articles, prepositions, voice and narration).
- NCERT, *Words and Expressions 2*, Class 10 English workbook (tenses, voice, reported speech, determiners, editing tasks).
- S.P. Bakshi, *Objective General English*, Arihant (error spotting, idioms, one-word substitutions).
- UPSC Recruitment Test papers with a General Ability Test, listed in the knowledge base (Vice Principal GNCTD 2022; EPFO EO/AO GAT 2025), for the question style.
- Oxford Advanced Learner's Dictionary (idiom meanings and confused word pairs).

Quick facts

- Along with, as well as, together with, with: the verb agrees with the first subject; only 'and' adds a subject.
- Either...or and neither...nor: the verb agrees with the subject nearer to it.
- 'A number of' takes a plural verb; 'the number of' takes a singular verb.
- Each, every, everyone, nobody, either, neither, many a, more than one: singular verb.
- Furniture, advice, information, news, luggage, scenery, equipment, stationery are uncountable: no -s, no a/an, singular verb.
- a/an goes by sound: an hour, an MLA, an FIR, an NGO; a university, a European, a one-rupee note.
- Since + point of time, for + period; present perfect never with yesterday, ago, last year or in 2019.
- Past perfect marks the earlier of two past actions; time clauses after when, until, as soon as take the present tense.
- If + past perfect pairs with would have + V3; 'would' never appears inside the if-clause; 'unless' already means 'if not'.
- No preposition after discuss, enter (a place), reach, resemble, comprise, order, attack, accompany.

- Senior, junior, superior, inferior, prior and prefer take 'to', never 'than'.
- Comparative for two, superlative for three or more; 'than any other city' needs 'other'.
- Passive voice: object becomes subject + be in the same tense + past participle + by doer; present perfect becomes has/have been + V3.
- Indirect speech with a past reporting verb: tense shifts back, will becomes would, tomorrow becomes the next day, yesterday the previous day, now then, here there.
- No tense shift when the reporting verb is present or future, or when the statement is a universal truth.